

Assignment on “To a Snail” in relation to other snail poems and semiotics (and other intertextual topics)

--Bonnie Costello

“To a Snail”: An assignment on intertextuality. This assignment works well in a modern poetry class, but also in a Introduction to Poetry. Put “To a Snail” next to Shakespeare’s “Venus and Adonis” [“Or, as the snail, whose tender horns being hit,/Shrinks backward in his shelly cave with pain,/And there, all smother'd up, in shade doth sit,/Long after fearing to creep forth again”]; Cowper’s “The Snail,” and Keats’ letter to Haydon April 1818: [“The innumerable compositions and decompositions which take place between the intellect and its thousand materials before it arrives at that trembling delicate and snail-horn perception of Beauty.”] What does Moore’s poetry tell us about the semiotics of the snail through literary history? It’s also interesting to bring in the Golden Ratio in support of Moore’s resignifying of the snail.

If Moore is in conversation with other snail-poets, she is also in conversation with herself. The draft of “To a Snail,” published in The Marianne Moore Newsletter, reveals the struggle she had with “compression.”

Other intertextual topics: Moore's "Poetry" is usefully put against Arthur Davison Ficke's 1912 "Poetry" which headed the inaugural issue of *Poetry Magazine*. "The Paper Nautilus" is usefully set against Oliver Wendell Holmes' "The Chambered Nautilus."